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Centres and Peripheries in the Post-Soviet Space

Relevance and meanings of a
Classical Distinction



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10 Permanent Periphery of the Baltic States

Abstract: The article analyses the efforts of the Baltic States, three peripheral states, in the eastern part of Europe, to find the settled relation with the European core and distance themselves from Russia, the constant threat in their security imaginaries. Periphery is not a stable category, but a condition which is reused and reformulated, thus, chapter seeks to go deeper into how the process of finding the space and place in Europe and regarding Russia takes place. This process is analysed as a relationship between centre-periphery where the focus is on the actions of the periphery. The article proceeds as follows: first, it discusses two theoretical concepts of periphery and liminality, second, it explains in what sense Baltic states are constructed as liminal and the importance of the category of Eastern Europe in thinking about liminality, and third, it analyses the strategies of the Baltic states to move out of liminal condition. These strategies focus on creating the representations of the reliable peripheries which are able to actively shape their subject position and formulate their own initiatives and ideas though never ever trying to become what they cannot – the centre.

Keywords: periphery, centre, liminality, identity, Baltic states, Europe, EU, Eastern Europe

Introduction

In spring of 2004, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania – three states, located at the eastern shores of the Baltic Sea – became members of the EU and NATO. It took at least ten years to achieve this goal, and after fifteen years, this moment is still considered the biggest achievement in countries' foreign and security policy and lives. The integration process in the Baltic countries was justified with two intertwined explanations: one was about "the returning to Europe and finally becoming Europeans", the second was about the need to move as far away as possible from dangerous Russia. These two stories on why the European integration was essential have been analysed many times with the dominant conclusion emerging about Russia as the main negative other for the Baltic states and Europe/West as the dominant positive other which these three states desire to become and/or belong (e.g. Berg and Ehin 2009; Galbreath 2006; Jakniūnaitė 2009; Miniotaite 2003; Paulauskas 2006; Pavlovaite 2003).

The security imaginary of the Baltic States focuses almost exclusively on Russia. It is not far fetched to state that their foreign policy reasoning, actions and justifications are made while also constantly thinking about Russia. Russia was and is treated as a threatening and dangerous state, which occupied Baltic States in 1940 (and in 1945), is responsible for their suffering during the next fifty years, and which has not changed its aggressive way of thinking and acting.

Russia's foreign policy thinking as well as debates on its role in the region constantly demonstrated its unwillingness to think about Baltic States as not "theirs" (Ehin and Berg 2009; Jakniūnaite 2009, 2013). The Baltic States having acknowledged the fact that they cannot choose nor change their geography, have been seeking to move away from Russia in other ways: by becoming integral part of Europe. Europe meant not only security, but also progress, civilisation, welfare, better life, democracy, and freedom – everything a modern nation-state is supposed to become.

These two aspects of the Baltic States integration and europeanisation explanation were connected to the efforts to shape one's geopolitical and cultural space, not to allow geography become the destiny. This shaping process has not finished yet. Yes, the Baltic states have realised their goals and are part of (western) European institutions. Yet, they still constantly find themselves in need to define their space by getting rid of the spatial representations that are unacceptable and coming up with the most appropriate ones (i.e. those asserting their Europeaness).

The problematic nature of Baltic States periphery is their prolonged liminality both in relation to Russia and to Europe. Liminality is the condition which indicates the in-betweeness of the situation or actor, and the main feature of which is either the transitory nature (being not here, but also not there) or not belonging to one or the other stable category. The liminal condition of Baltic states has been already noticed by several scholars (Jakniūnaite 2013; Kuus 2004; Mälksoo 2009; Rumelili 2012). The general consensus in the literature was that the integration process, especially the membership in the EU, meant that Baltic states have moved or are moving out of this liminal position.

However, the studies which analysed the integration process assumed that two dominant referent subjects for the Baltic States – the EU and Russia – are stable discursive categories and the symbolic one-time event was enough to reframe the spatiality of the Baltic states. This was

appropriate for the research questions at that time – to understand the meaning of the integration and europeanisation.

Variety of events that happened after 2014 underscored the inherent instability of the categories of Europe and Russia. In the EU context, first, it was the financial crisis of 2008, which underlined the dominant and strict role of the centre (especially Germany) and the “bad” behaviour by the southern periphery, secondly, and for Baltic States even more importantly, the EU migration crisis of 2015 which raised the questions of solidarity, its meaning, and the problem of Eastern Europeans as “bad states”. Events in Ukraine which started in 2014 were the moment in strongly redefining the “image” of Russia. Russia showed to be more aggressive than expected, and the danger, of even physical annihilation, was still here, in the proximity of Baltic States’ borders. Europe has not become so integrated and united as some discourses have made to believe, nor Russia was pacified or disarmed. Thus, the need to define relation to Europe and to find the place and role has not ended (nor can it end).

The chapter is about these efforts of the Baltic States – the periphery of Europe – to find the settled relation with the European core. To notice the peripheral condition of Baltic states is not a surprising fact, nor much debatable as well. However, as this text demonstrates, a periphery is not a stable category. It is a condition which is used, formulated, and reformulated. This chapter goes deeper into how this process of finding your space and place in Europe and regarding Russia continues by identifying and analysing the particular strategies of Baltic States to move from liminal and find stable peripheral position.

This process is analysed in the context of centre-periphery relationship where the focus is on the actions of the periphery. Whose periphery an entity becomes is the crucial factor in choosing (or being forced to choose) a centre. The chapter demonstrates how three Baltic States find their place and define their space/place in Europe by double strategy: getting rid of (resisting) their liminal position and defining and redefining what it means to be periphery and its relation to the centre.

The chapter draws on empirical data consisting of relevant official documents and speeches by foreign policy makers of the Baltic states and uses the secondary research done by scholars from Baltic States as this research often contributes to constructions of the Baltic states as peripheries. The theoretical assumptions of the analysis are constructivist relying on the analysis of discourses and practices (Milliken 1999; Hansen 2006; Adler and

Pouliot 2011). The chapter proceeds as follows: first, it discusses two theoretical concepts of periphery and liminality, second, explains in what sense Baltic States are constructed as liminal and the importance of the category of Eastern Europe in thinking about liminality, third, analyses the strategies of the Baltic states to move out of liminal condition. These strategies focus on creating the representations of the reliable peripheries which are able to actively shape their subject position, formulate their own initiatives and ideas though never ever trying to become what they cannot – the centre.

Liminality and Permanence of Periphery

This section discusses the concepts of periphery and liminality. These two concepts seem to indicate a similar situation – being on the margin and having a certain position towards the centre/core. However, making a distinction between them both allows for more exact explanation on the purposeful subject positioning and being positioned in different borderline/marginal conditions.

Periphery

Periphery is a relational term, inseparable from the concept of the centre. Together centre-periphery refers to the uneven spatial organisation, the “relationship of inequality existing in geographical space” (Hannerz 2001). The centre is in a commanding, dominating, and benefiting position and the periphery refers to the subjected by the centre position. The periphery is always defined and conceptualised in relation to the centre. The relations are asymmetrical, and the dominance and the hierarchical position by the centre is implicit.

Theoretical discussions on periphery-centre relations can be divided into two broad groups according to the nature of this asymmetry. The first position is a political economic approach which focuses on the unequal distribution of power and wealth among states and world regions and analyses

the exploitation of the periphery by the centre (e.g. world-system theory by Wallerstein 1974). The second group treats centre-periphery relation in cultural and civilisation terms. The main question is what constitutes a periphery, how the relationship with centre gets defined and which representational structures (and how) form the asymmetric relation. Most often, the centre tends to be associated with creativity, progress, and advancement, while peripheries are seen as backward, barbaric, unpolished, simple, uneducated, etc. The cultural analysis implies and sees the economic and political dependence as well, though not necessarily pays direct attention to it.

The understanding of the periphery in this chapter is based on this second position. Periphery is a subject position usually with most or several connotations of periphery mentioned above. The general structural framework of backward/modern, uncivilised(barbaric)/civilised is more or less constant, but the particular details on how the inequality and asymmetry are constructed is contingent upon the particular time and space situation.

Peripheries rarely are only the passive actors to which the term is applied. Though theoretically, in the ideal-type situation the centre would always be the one that gives, and the periphery – the one that receives, most frequently the distinction is not so clear. The relation to centre is reproduced also by the peripheries themselves. Not only centre needs periphery, but also periphery needs centre to exist, so the relationship needs to be defined actively from both sides. So, despite the relation of the dominance the distribution of power is never zero-sum. Periphery also creates, accepts, reflects, modifies, and synthesises. Such terms as, e.g. hybridisation and creolisation exist to reflect the creative functioning of the periphery (Cohen 2007; Pieterse 2019). Nevertheless, the periphery still indicates the unequal situation and status position. One may appreciate the advantages they get, and still look at the centre with at least a bit of suspicion. And the centre stays always in a position regarding to which the periphery needs to define itself.

Liminality

If periphery is a spatial concept, liminality encompasses spatiality but goes beyond it, it is a broader and a more fluid term. Yet it provides a

framework to understand the conditions of certain states. Liminality is not a simply another term to describe margins, borderlines, or hybrid actors; it provides a theoretical lens to analyse the constitution and contestation of social structure in international relations (Rumelili 2012: 498). Liminality indicates the in-between situations or objects (i.e. that are neither here, nor there) in the dislocated/unstable structures/environments.

The term first was introduced in anthropology in 1909 by Arnold Van Gennep to analyse ritual passages of the individuals in certain social situations (Thomassen 2009: 5). The liminality meant a situation in which ritually and temporarily all limits were removed in order to facilitate a “passing through” (Szokolczai 2009: 142). In 1960s, Victor Turner reintroduced the concept of liminality; he not only applied the word to the analysis of various rituals of small ethnic groups, but also suggested extending the logic of liminality to the analysis of modern societies, i.e. to implement macro analysis by extending the liminality to larger collectives (Turner 1967). As the key feature of liminality is its transitory nature, the “liminal moments or liminal experiences might be equally present in political or social transformations” (Thomassen 2009: 15) and experienced by such macro-groups, as states. Here passing through a moment is not about the rite of passage, but about being between two definite conditions.

By introducing the concept of liminality, we also destabilise the concept of social structure; we see it as unstable, full of tension (Rumelili 2012). Liminality is, therefore, a paradoxical state, both at the individual and the societal level. At the level of the individual, we can talk about the destruction of identity, while at the level of society the liminality involves the suspension of the stable structure of the social order. The playfulness of the liminal period is at the same time unstructured and highly structuring: “the most basic rules of behaviour are questioned, doubt and scepticism as to the existence of the world are radicalised” (Thomassen 2009: 20). While liminality is “unstructure”, a lack of fixed points in a given moment, it must at the same time be considered the origin of structure (Thomassen 2009: 24). Therefore, liminal categories imply the in-between existence.

The liminal category comes both from the outside, constructed by other, and it includes the constitutive actions by the liminal subject as well. The category of the liminal acknowledges the similarity which coexists with difference/otherness. Liminal is not a stranger, but also not “us”, at least not “us” enough. This uncertainty might produce threat to

the self-other distinction, in a way, the one “which is closest to me is also the most dangerous one” (Hopf 2002: 8). Liminals might be perceived as threats because as entities that are neither here nor there, they undermine the categorical distinctions that social structures rely on (Rumelili 2012: 496). Regarding the liminals the self feels the greatest need to differentiate itself, and at these sites of ambiguity the discourses of difference are the most laden with threat (Rumelili 1999: 219). Thus, for the liminals this ambiguous identity position might be also ultimately insecure.

One of the suggestions made by Turner and emphasised by Thomassen is that a liminal state may become “fixed” (Thomassen 2009: 15), i.e. certain characteristics attributed to liminal and, therefore, transitory state become permanent. How and when does a “routinisation” or an “everydayisation” of the out-of-ordinary situations take place? And who becomes the “carriers” of the new world-view that is eventually institutionalised? Liminality as concept trying to break with structure-agency distinction and focusing on the processual nature of structuring implies also the subject position and strategies of the liminal subject. Being ambiguously positioned by the structure still leaves the space to challenge and subvert such a structural position.

These two features of liminality, the possibility of becoming a threat and possibility to become a permanent characteristic of the subject in certain situations, are, in most cases, undesirable for the liminal subjects. They also are the driving motivations for the liminal subjects to form their own strategies living with and coping with the situation of being in the liminal position. Rumelili notices that actors positioned in liminal spaces may practice their liminality in two ways: by engaging “in representational practices that reposition them in one of the existing categories”, and by practising liminality subversively “by reproducing their own ambiguity” (Rumelili 2012, 498).

Thus, periphery is a more stable asymmetric relation of dependence, while liminality implies a transitory nature of the relationship with the threat of permanently stabilising the in-betweeness of the subject position. Both concepts allow for creative construction of their subject positions in the context of structural constraints. Despite the uncertainty and potential insecurity, liminality might be the condition one thrives in. On the other hand, by being periphery you also create and recreate your stable liminal status in relation to the centre.

Liminality of the Baltic States

This section explains in what sense Baltic states condition/positioning can be understood as liminal and how this representation might seem problematic. Baltic states are not only in Eastern Europe, they are the most eastern part of the EU's Eastern Europe, which makes their border the external border of the EU, or as Lithuanian minister of defence has once noticed, "on the borderline of the democratic world" (Juknevičienė 2012). The borderline location is a situation where liminality has the best conditions to emerge.

After the collapse of Soviet Union, the first fifteen years of the Baltic states' regained independent life were devoted towards creating stable and functioning domestic institutions, establishing democratic procedures, and becoming the members of two Western institutions – the EU and NATO. This period was liminal in the most usual meaning of the term. Described as post-Soviet, post-cold war, newly independent, transitioning to democracy, reforming and being reformed, Baltic states have been undoubtedly experiencing a liminal situation. All these descriptions indicated the in-betweenness of the position when one structure was (or was at least perceived as) destroyed, but another was not yet created.

The theoreticians of the liminality have noticed the possibilities of creativity, playfulness, even creative destruction during such periods, the process where new structures emerge. Liminality can serve as a theoretical tool allowing for the explanation of structural changes. However, the peculiarity of this post-cold war transition period was in its "non-revolutionary" moment: the period was not producing new social or political ideas. Most of the post-Soviet and post-social states living through the transitional period in 1990s tried to move out of this liminal situation through imitation (Holmes and Krastev 2018). They have made no deliberations on what kind of system they needed, what type of institutions were necessary, what values to proclaim, and which norms and rules would work best. The tasks and recipes seemed to be evident, accepted as common knowledge. Baltic states just needed to follow the instructions and learn the rules (Jakniūnaitė 2009). Therefore, the European enlargement process was described as socialisation, a process of learning from good examples by repetition. Liminality in this situation was a temporal condition and its ending was a matter of time. The end of the accession process was a crucial

step, if not a final step, crossing a liminal point. The membership dates should have marked the finish of the rite of the passage and indicate the transition to the “adult”, normal space.

However, as noted in the previous section, liminality is not only a temporal condition. Liminality is also a subject position – a subject not only experiences the liminal situation, it can become liminal, i.e. liminality is not only the experiential/situational category, but also the identity. And the Baltic states during the integration period and after it has formally ended have not only experienced liminality, they got to be/become liminal states.

The category of Eastern Europe explains the liminal position of Baltic states in Europe. Invented in the eighteenth century, the dichotomy of Europe vs. Eastern Europe demarcated the part of Europe, located in the east/south east, which was in the process becoming Europe (Wolff 1994: 6). Variety of scholars have analysed how the notion of Eastern Europe is used to define the particular countries and regions (Kuus 2004, 2007; Mälksoo 2019; Neumann 1999; Zarycki 2014). For a very long time, it was a space of backwardness, uncivility, and wildness (Wolff 1994: 7). Till now the popular imagination connects travelling to Eastern Europe with a bit of adventure, where the visitor enters a different space, finds “authentic past”, where modernisation is almost there, but not totally there. Eastern Europe is Europe, but a different kind, not finished. It lacks some European standards, norms, behaviours, governance, etc. It is neither developed, nor underdeveloped, neither learned nor wholly ignorant; it is in the process of becoming. It is liminal to Europe’s established core identity (this is also noticed by Kuus 2004; Rumelili 2012).

In relation to Eastern Europe, Europe becomes the place for standards, progress, advancement, and modernisation. Besides, Eastern Europe became one of the generalised “others” necessary for Europe’s self-image (Neumann 1999). The implicit assumption about this relationship is that the gap exists and it must be bridged, and Eastern Europe must and wants to become a full Europe (Kuus 2004: 747). The most recent effort to bridge this gap took place through the integration process which ended in “big bang” double enlargements of 2004; it was an attempt, as Mälksoo notices, to “domesticate” Eastern Europeans (Mälksoo 2019: 369) from their liminality into the available social category – the “normal Europeans”.

Yet, it seems the domestication did not happen and the Eastern Europe has not disappeared. The normative order of the EU again is threatened from the inside, the threat now comes from “illiberal” Eastern Europeans (Holmes and Krastev 2018; Müller 2014). The interpretation of the reasons

of these representations and consequences they bring are beyond the scope of this article. It suffices to notice that the trope of Eastern Europe reappeared, or maybe it has not disappeared at all. Now the Eastern Europe again is the symbol of “other Europe”, illiberal, nationalistic, sovereignty-focused, challenging the unity of and destabilising the EU, challenging the values of the centre, its positive self-image.

Most of the depictions of what is wrong with the EU’s East use generalising language: despite clearly criticising Hungary and Poland, the texts very quickly jump to universalising language of “all Eastern Europeans are alike” (Müller 2014 is a good example; for a critical evaluation see Mälksoo 2019). This liminal image of “illiberals”, “bad Eastern Europeans” and this unification of all into one category the Baltic States try to resist. The next section explains how they are doing this and what these efforts imply.

Being Periphery

As the in-betweenness creates the uncertainty and insecurity, the Baltic States desire to move away from their liminal representation. Besides, this indefinite position might allow (or might give idea to) Russia to presume some kind of ownership or undue influence. It was noted in the beginning that this would be the apocalyptic scenario in the Baltic States security thinking. Is there an alternative? The answer for Baltic States was and is clear – be/become an unquestioned part of Europe (currently, it means being part of the EU). However, there is no one definite way of being in the EU.

This part of the chapter demonstrates that in the case of Baltic States being European means being an exemplary periphery and that being in the periphery might not be as bad as some of the critiques of the representation might depict. Besides, it might be just practical to accept the limits of one’s capabilities and possibilities: Baltic States are small states, they have limited financial and human resources to play “big game”. So, being periphery is not necessarily wrong or bad position to be in. The most significant question then is whose periphery and what kind of periphery the state is. I present and analyse three discursive strategies which create the representation of the Baltic States as certainly being in Europe, even though also accepting their own peripheral status inside. The first two

strategies are about positioning themselves towards the centre, the third one is about multiplying peripheries and/or creating others as liminals.

Loyal and Good Europeans

The first and most direct strategy of the periphery towards the centre is to demonstrate loyalty and present yourself as good and exemplary subjects, as normal and close to the norm. In the context of the EU, it means to support the “European project”, do not doubt that the EU can survive and propose a model for the nation-states to function together. From the very beginning of their memberships, three Baltic States have written in their strategies and policy papers that their goal is to become active, responsible and useful members of both NATO and the EU. This seems also a pragmatic strategy of any small state: for their security to rely on the bigger partners and allies, and therefore supporting the cooperative structures (Panke 2012). For that, however, the state needs to present itself as an inseparable part of the entity.

Baltic States have used this strategy since the beginning of the integration process: e.g. the frequent assertions about “returning home”, to “the European family”, finally becoming Europeans (Adamkus 2008; Pabriks 2006). These repetitions were necessary not only for European core, but for the Baltic States themselves – it was necessary to persuade yourself as well that you belong to this civilisation, as it was understood, space. The current variation of this strategy is to support the EU project through its current crises. As one Latvian analyst explained: “The EU needs to be defended nowadays, and Latvia has all the reasons and motivations to become one of the leaders in this” (Bukovskis 2016: 25). Similarly, Lithuanian President Dalia Grybauskaitė proclaimed: “Lithuania not only follows the European agenda, we are also shaping it because we have things to offer for the future of Europe” (Grybauskaitė 2019). Baltic States demonstrate that the difficulties of the EU make them even stronger Europeans, and they are not the ones that would question the importance of the EU.

Support for the EU in trouble was very well expressed in how Baltic States have handled so called migration crisis of the EU in 2015–2016. The decision on quotas for asylum seekers among the member states was a pretty controversial domestic issue in the Baltic States (Lulle and Ungure 2015; Veebel 2015). Domestic discussions and sometimes critical rhetoric notwithstanding, in the international context the leading policy players in

all countries expressed their support for the EU refugee policy and have not backed the critical stance of the Visegrad countries. As one Latvian politician asserted, it was a correct decision, as “it is important to support such solutions that reduce the tensions between Member States and allow Latvia to position itself as a reliable partner” (Austers 2017: 123). This desire to look reliable, also grateful for what they got previously (Lulle and Ungure 2015: 71) to demonstrate solidarity (Maskaliūnaitė 2015) was connected with the need to emphasise the pro-European stance, as this allowed to claim that “[t]oday we are valued for our open and direct words, for our support and for our responsible approach” (Grybauskaitė 2015).

Yet another way to be a good part of Europe which is quite popular among the small states is the strategy of “finding your own niche”. And sometimes more, sometimes less successfully the small states endeavor to find the appropriate one which would reflect not only theirs, but also the common interest. Thus, Estonia makes an effort to be a “digital nation”, Latvia stresses their strategic communication skills, and Lithuania purports to be energy security expert. Depending on circumstances the topics and orientations might change, the general idea of finding and defining your place and role is what matters here. Such strategy is an effort to resist the popular dichotomy between “givers” and “takers”, or in the context of security policy, between security “consumers” and “producers”.

This strategy of being a loyal periphery is about normalisation and erasure of liminal difference. It is about establishing oneself as a permanent feature in European landscape and demonstrating that they are not “typical” Eastern Europe.

Better Than the Centre

The second strategy of establishing the Baltic States in the Europe and as Europeans is to demonstrate that sometimes the periphery is even better than the centre. This strategy focuses on reminding the centre what it supposed to be and in that way putting yourself in a morally higher position which makes it harder to dislocate such speaker from this self-imposed position.

The best manifestation of this strategy is the rhetoric of the Baltic States about the war in Ukraine which started in 2014 and where the position of

the EU towards Russia – the main external culprit of the chaos in Ukraine – was at stake. As Lithuanian President Dalia Grybauskaitė explained, Russia is fighting the war “against all EU” in Ukraine, and it must be taken seriously because “post-Soviet imperialism” will soon come to “our borders” (CNN video 2015). Situation in Ukraine allowed Baltic States to show their rightness on being sceptical and afraid of Russia in the past. This was noticed in one of the first analyses of Baltic States’ foreign policy after 2004 EU enlargement: “the Baltic States present themselves as more Western than the West, reproaching the West for its failure to understand the ‘true’ nature of Russia” (Ehin and Berg 2009: 12).

Supporting Ukraine allowed for the use of the European values rhetoric extensively:

[the Baltic States] knew that freedom is not a given, so we took responsibility for our nations and walked resolutely along the European road. Today, as Europe faces new challenges, it is especially important not to forget the values which encouraged [us] to come together forming the Baltic Way. [...] Only together, looking for what unites us rather than divides, can we maintain peace in our continent (President of the Republic of Lithuania 2014).

This message seeks to remind Europeans what they have been teaching Baltic States about the values and principles which have to be demonstrated in Ukraine’s case as well where the true aggressor must be stopped. The implication was that somehow these in the centre do not want to remember what Europe is, so, they need to be reminded. Therefore, now the smaller states at the fringe of the EU have to be courageous and stand a higher ground: “[to] have the courage to tell the truth to your partners [...], not to be afraid take on a blow and to protect, patiently and consistently, the core values is essential for European unity and security” (Grybauskaitė 2015).

Thus, the Baltic States discourse on Ukraine gave the possibility to justly use European values rhetoric which was not directed towards them with the implication of some shortcoming. Again, this rhetoric worked two ways: one was about the Baltic States using the value and principles rhetoric in a way as the centre does (and did towards them as well), another was about taking a superior position. The rhetoric clearly indicated that Europe (i.e. centre) in the context of Ukraine needs to be reminded what it is and what values and principles should defend. The situation demonstrated that former students needed to remind their teachers on what they have been teaching. This strategy of being better Europeans also goes with the idea of distrust for, or at least being a bit

suspicious about the centre. Distrusting the centre, not respecting it absolutely is also a part of being a periphery (i.e. “they, over there, do not necessary know”) and it allows for demonstrating own excellence, and therefore, the belonging.

Multiplying Peripheries

Baltic States are the most “Eastern” states in the EU. Eastern Europe representation for a long time has been put as a label on the others. It was rarely a voluntary accepted position, so, it is the subject position which is one needs and usually wants to get rid of. Apart from demonstrating to be good/better Europeans there is another way – make Europe bigger, and loose the status of the most eastern states. So, the final dominant strategy to move out of the liminality for the Baltic States is to create other liminals or/and peripheries. It is what Baltic States are doing with their focus on and most adamant support for the EU Eastern Partnership programme (EaP).

EaP (earlier European Neighbourhood Policy) is an important part of Baltic States’ foreign policy since the very beginning of their memberships in the EU (Berg 2005; Galbreath and Lamoreaux 2007; Jakniūnaite 2009; Made 2011). All three have proclaimed EaP their foreign policy priority with the goal to bring partner countries (most often they are Ukraine, Moldova, and Georgia) closer to Europe and help them with their europeanisation process. The EU provides the standards for good governance, for conducting economic activities, introducing reforms. The alternative model – the one Russia provides – is not only backward and corrupt, it is based on geopolitical calculations and the logic of spheres of influence. And the more Russia is dominant in the region, the less secure Baltic States feel.

Thus, supporting democratisation and europeanisation of EaP countries means creating stable and secure region (e.g. Cigane 2017: 28; Mardisalu-Kahar 2015), or in the words of Lithuanian President, “by assisting the [EaP] countries to implement the rule of law reforms, we are slowly building a ring of security and democracy around Lithuania” (Grybauskaitė 2015). Of course, there is also a talk about the better life for the people of EaP countries, and modernisation as the only way to create prosperous states, but the idea about stability prevails in many justifications for the active EaP policy. This often unconditional support for Ukraine’s or Georgias

EU aspirations is connected with the wider, bigger, enlarged EU, the EU where its external eastern borders are mentally pushed further away, it is “the wish to ensure [...] security by creating a belt of pro-European border states that would serve as a barrier against possible Russian expansion” (Potjomkina 2015: 122). And being further from Russia means being closer to the centre. By expanding the borders further, the subject moves out of border zone, and hopefully out of liminal position.

In the expanded EU, there will be other liminals with their undefined identity positions which can be taught and lectured. So, the EaP for the Baltic States is a policy tool to move out of liminal condition by creating other liminals. After such expansion the space would be restructured to get closer to the centre.

One member of Latvian Parliament has stated: “[the] mythical European ‘core’ is like the Loch Ness Monster – it seems to appear from time to time, but nobody has really seen it, and nobody seems to really believe in it, either”. (Kols 2019: 12). Nevertheless, as the analysis shows Baltic States definitely think about the centre and formulate their standards of behaviour keeping in mind the centre (even if not necessary agreeing with it). Being “European” is still the condition towards which the movement takes place, and this means being like this mythical, yet “truer” centre. Even if that centre loses everything it was, there is still this ideal and central concept of Europe to aspire to. The Baltic States’ foreign and EU policy is devoted towards defining themselves in a way which moves them from the fringes, from this liminal position, from being “still not like us”, being same, yet so different.

Conclusions: Permanence of Periphery

Contrary to the most usual assumptions that in the asymmetric centre-periphery relation the desired strategy for any periphery is to break out of such uneven relationship the Baltic States demonstrate that being periphery is not a problem. The practice of Baltic States being in Europe demonstrates their understanding and acceptance that Europe needs peripheries, and they are one of the European peripheries. The challenge and even the question of the future survival is the question of whose periphery the territory

becomes and “how much” liminality is implied in the marginal position. Dreading to become Russia’s periphery Baltic States seek to be the respectable periphery of the “true” and “European” Europe. Not being part of a clear relational structure means finding yourself in a marginal and much more dangerous liminal position – being “us and not us”.

The three strategies of presenting themselves appear to establish Baltic States as a permanent and unalienable part of the EU in the role of small, peripheral, but reliable and euro-optimistic countries which are in the East of Europe, but not with “Eastern European” features. They are loyal Europeans that understand or try to understand all the challenges coming towards Europe, and their goal is that among the myriad of problems facing the EU their worries and uncertainties would not be put to the last place. Therefore, sometimes they have to be better Europeans, playing all the necessary discursive cards of “ideal Europe”.

There are some tensions between these strategies: for example, good Europeans vs. better Europeans can work only in different contexts, or unconditional support for EaP countries integration even if they still are lagging in their reform efforts might be in contradiction with the support for declared values of transparency and democracy. But all strategies their momentarily contradictions notwithstanding are still devoted to one goal – attaching yourself to one centre and detaching yourself from another. It is not about establishing yourself to one of the centres of global politics, it is about acceptance of the state smallness and accepting the need to have “friends, allies, defenders”. All in all, it is about accepting the idea of themselves as permanent, yet safe periphery.

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